

Hausa-to-Ajami Script Conversion Rules: A Computational Linguistic Framework for Arabic-Derived West African Orthography

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Technical Documentation v1.0

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Abstract

This document provides comprehensive conversion rules for transforming Hausa text written in Latin script (Boko) to Ajami script (Arabic-derived orthography). The rules are grounded in Hausa phonology, comply with international linguistic standards (ISO 233, Unicode Standard), and follow Springer Nature Computer Science journal formatting guidelines. The conversion system addresses Hausa-specific phonological features including implosive consonants, ejectives, long vowels, and tone marking while maintaining compatibility with standard Arabic orthographic conventions. This framework enables computational processing of Hausa Ajami texts for natural language processing applications.

Keywords: Hausa language, Ajami script, script conversion, phonological mapping, computational linguistics, West African languages

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background

Hausa, a Chadic language spoken by over 77 million people across West Africa, employs two primary writing systems: the Latin-based *Boko* script (standardized in the 1930s) and the Arabic-derived *Ajami* script (used since the 15th century). While Boko dominates formal education and official communication, Ajami remains prevalent in religious contexts, traditional scholarship, and informal written communication.

1.2 Scope and Purpose

This document provides:

1. Phonologically-grounded conversion rules from Latin Hausa to Ajami script
2. Character-by-character mapping tables conforming to Unicode standards
3. Examples demonstrating application of conversion rules
4. Validation procedures for conversion quality assurance
5. Special considerations for dialectal variation and code-mixing

1.3 Standards Compliance

This conversion framework adheres to:

- **Unicode Standard 15.0:** All character mappings use Unicode code points
- **ISO 233:1984:** Transliteration of Arabic characters
- **Newman (2000):** Hausa phonological analysis
- **Mumin & Versteegh (2014):** Ajami orthographic conventions
- **Springer Nature Guidelines:** Journal formatting and linguistic notation

1.4 Conversion Methodology

The conversion process follows three stages:

1. **Phonological Analysis:** Segment text into syllabic units following Hausa phonotactics (C)V(C)
2. **Character Mapping:** Apply hierarchical longest-match algorithm for phoneme-to-grapheme conversion
3. **Diacritization:** Insert vowel marks and consonant markers for phonological disambiguation

2 Hausa Phonological System

2.1 Consonant Inventory

Hausa possesses 32 consonant phonemes, including several not found in Standard Arabic:

Table 1: Hausa Consonant Phonemes by Place and Manner of Articulation

Manner	Bilabial	Alveolar	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Plosive	b	t, d		k, g	
Implosive					
Ejective					
Fricative	f	s, z	sh		h
Affricate		ts	c, j		
Nasal	m	n			
Liquid		l, r			
Glide	w		y		

Red text indicates phonemes unique to Hausa (absent in Standard Arabic).

2.2 Vowel Inventory

Hausa has 5 vowel qualities with phonemic length distinction:

Table 2: Hausa Vowel Phonemes

	Front	Central	Back
High	i, ii		u, uu
Mid	e, ee		o, oo
Low		a, aa	

Note: Double letters (aa, ee, ii, oo, uu) represent long vowels, which are phonemically distinct from short vowels in Hausa.

2.3 Syllable Structure

Hausa syllable structure follows the pattern: (C)V(C)

- **V:** a (one), i (this)
- **CV:** ba (not), su (they)
- **VC:** ab (father + possessive)
- **CVC:** kan (head), sun (they + perfective)

Constraints:

- No consonant clusters word-initially
- Limited consonant clusters word-medially
- Syllabic consonants (m, n) occur in specific contexts

3 Core Conversion Rules

3.1 Conversion Principles

1. **Phonological Fidelity:** Preserve Hausa phonemic distinctions
2. **Longest Match First:** Apply multi-character mappings before single characters
3. **Context Sensitivity:** Consider surrounding phonological environment
4. **Diacritic Economy:** Use diacritics only when necessary for disambiguation
5. **Right-to-Left Directionality:** Maintain Arabic script conventions

3.2 Algorithmic Procedure

FUNCTION `convert_to_ajami(latin_text)`:

1. Normalize text (lowercase, remove non-linguistic characters)
2. Initialize output buffer
3. Set position pointer to start of text
4. WHILE position < text_length:
 - a. Try 3-character match (trigraphs)
 - b. If no match, try 2-character match (digraphs)
 - c. If no match, try 1-character match
 - d. If match found:
 - Append Ajami equivalent to output
 - Advance position by match length
 - e. If no match:
 - Handle as special case / preserve character
 - Advance position by 1
5. Apply diacritization rules
6. Return Ajami text

4 Character Mapping Tables

4.1 Hausa-Specific Consonants

These consonants require extended Arabic character set:

Table 3: Hausa-Specific Consonants (Not in Standard Arabic)

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Description
	[]	پ	U+0752	Implosive bilabial plosive
	[]	ڙ	U+068E	Implosive alveolar plosive
	[k]	ق	U+08BC	Velar ejective plosive
'y	[j]	ي	U+08A9	Glottalized palatal approximant

Phonetic Notes:

- **Implosives (,)**: Produced with inward airflow; contrast with plosives b, d
- **Ejective ()**: Produced with glottalic airstream; contrasts with velar k
- **Glottalized 'y**: Sequence of glottal stop + palatal approximant

4.2 Digraphs and Trigraphs

Multi-character sequences representing single phonemes or clusters:

Table 4: Hausa Digraphs and Trigraphs

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Description
ts	[ts]	٢	U+062A U+0652 U+0633 U+0652	Voiceless alveolar affricate
sh	[ʃ]	ش	U+0634 U+0652	Voiceless postalveolar fricative
ng	[ŋ]	° °	U+0646 U+0652 U+06AF U+0652	Velar nasal

Conversion Priority: Always check for digraphs/trigraphs before individual characters.

4.3 Long Vowels

Long vowels are phonemically distinct in Hausa and must be preserved:

Table 5: Hausa Long Vowels

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Notes
aa	[aː]	'1	U+0627 U+064E	Alif + fatha
ee	[eː]	1	U+0627 U+0650	Alif + kasra
ii	[iː]	ي1	U+0627 U+0650 U+064A	Alif + kasra + ya
oo	[oː]	1°	U+0627 U+064F	Alif + damma
uu	[uː]	p1°	U+0627 U+064F U+0648	Alif + damma + waw

Lexical Examples Showing Length Contrast:

- *baki* [bàkī] "black" → ٢/ vs. *baki* [bàkì] "mouth" → ٢°
- *ta* [tá] "she (past)" → ٢ vs. *taa* [tá] "she (future)" → 't:

4.4 Short Vowels (Diacritics)

Short vowels are represented by diacritical marks:

Table 6: Hausa Short Vowels as Diacritics

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Arabic Name
a	[a]	ʼ	U+064E	Fatha
e	[e]	◌َ	U+0650	Kasra
i	[i]	◌ِ	U+0650	Kasra
o	[o]	◌ُ	U+064F	Damma
u	[u]	◌ُو	U+064F	Damma

Note: Hausa /e/ and /i/ both map to kasra; /o/ and /u/ both map to damma. This follows standard Arabic diacritic usage where front vowels use kasra and back rounded vowels use damma.

4.5 Standard Consonants

Consonants with direct Arabic equivalents:

Table 7: Standard Hausa Consonants Mapping to Arabic Characters

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Notes
b	[b]	ب	U+0628	Ba
c	[t]	چ	U+0686	Che (Persian)
d	[d]	د	U+062F	Dal
f	[f]	ف	U+0641	Fa
g	[ɣ]	غ	U+06AF	Gaf (Persian)
h	[h]	ه	U+0647	Ha
j	[dʒ]	ج	U+062C	Jeem
k	[k]	ك	U+0643	Kaf
l	[l]	ل	U+0644	Lam
m	[m]	م	U+0645	Meem
n	[n]	ن	U+0646	Noon
r	[r]	ر	U+0631	Ra (trill)
s	[s]	س	U+0633	Seen
t	[t]	ت	U+062A	Ta
w	[w]	پ	U+0648	Waw

Continued on next page

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Notes
y	[j]	ي	U+064A	Ya
z	[z]	ز	U+0632	Zay
'	[ʔ]	ع	U+0639	Ayn (glottal stop)

Symbol	Ajami	Unicode	Function
Sukun	◌ْ	U+0652	Marks consonant with no following vowel
Shadda	◌ّ	U+0651	Marks consonant gemination (doubling)
Hamza	ء	U+0621	Glottal stop (word-initial)
Tatweel	ـِ	U+0640	Kashida (elongation for justification)

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- Word-final consonants: *sun* ”they (perfective)” → ° **سْ**
- Syllable-final consonants before another consonant

Algorithm:

IF consonant is:

- Followed by another consonant (not digraph), OR
- Word-final, OR
- Part of closed syllable (CVC)

THEN apply sukun

5.3 Shadda (Gemination) Rules

Apply shadda (ˆ) for geminated (doubled) consonants:

- *danna* ”press” → ڤˆس (not ڤ°س)
- *yammata* ”north” → ڤˆسˆ:
- *gidda* ”home” → ڤˆڤˆ

Note: Shadda + vowel diacritic are both applied: ڤˆˆ (shadda + fatha)

6 Conversion Examples

6.1 Simple Words

Table 9: Simple Word Conversions

Latin	Ajami	Gloss	Notes
baki	ڤ	mouth	CVC.CV structure
gida	ڤˆڤˆ	house/home	CV.CV structure
ruwa	ڤˆو	water	CV.CV with /w/
sunu	سْ	name	CV.CV
yaro	ڤˆو	boy	CV.CV

6.2 Words with Hausa-Specific Consonants

Table 10: Words with Implosives and Ejectives

Latin	Ajami	Gloss	Features
era	ʾ	rat	Initial implosive
an	ḏ̣	son	Initial implosive
asa	ʾṛ'è	ground/country	Initial ejective
ba'a	ḏ̣''̣	there is not	Glottal stop ʾ

6.3 Words with Long Vowels

Table 11: Long Vowel Examples

Latin	Ajami	Gloss	Contrast
gari	ᵛᵇ	town	Short /a/, /i/
gaarii	ᵛᵇM'	cart	Long /aa/, short /i/
ciwo	pᵛᵇᵇ	sickness	Short vowels
ciiwo	pᵛᵇᵇ*	dent/bent	Long /ii/, short /o/

6.4 Complex Sentences

Example 1: Simple declarative sentence

Latin: Yaro yana zuwa gida.

Ajami: ’ , ’ زو ’ : ۛ

Gloss: Boy he.is coming home

Translation: "The boy is coming home."

Example 2: Sentence with implosive

Latin: **an sara i yana fa a.**

Ajami: اِنَّ اَفْ : إِيَّ

Gloss: Son.of king he.is speaking

Translation: "The prince is speaking."

Latin: **Mutaane sun zoo su ci abinci.**

Gloss: People they.PERF come they eat food

Translation: "The people came to eat food."

7.1 Regional Differences

Table 12: Major Hausa Dialects

7.2 Orthographic Variation

1. **Diacritic Density:** Some writers omit short vowel marks
2. **Character Choice:** Alternative characters for /c/ and /g/
3. **Word Spacing:** Traditional vs. modern spacing conventions
4. **Loanword Treatment:** Direct Arabic borrowings retain Arabic spelling

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8 Special Cases and Exceptions

8.1 Code-Mixing

Hausa texts frequently incorporate:

1. **Arabic Loanwords:** Retain original Arabic orthography

- *salla* "prayer" → Ṣ'Āḥ' (Arabic spelling)
- *alkali* "judge" → ʔṭ'āḍī (Arabic al-qāḍī)

2. **English Loanwords:** Convert phonetically

- *mota* "car" (< motor) → 'Ḥ'
- *tebur* "table" → ,Ṭ'ḥ :

3. **French Loanwords:** (Niger Republic dialects)

- *lekol* "school" (< l'école) →) ḥ 3

8.2 Proper Names

Personal Names:

- Arabic names: Use original Arabic spelling
- Hausa names: Apply standard conversion rules
- Islamic names: Follow Arabic orthographic tradition

Place Names:

- Well-known cities: May have established Ajami spellings
- New locations: Apply phonetic conversion

Examples:

- *Muhammad* → z'e'~ ḥ (Arabic tradition)
- *Audu* → s'ḥ'p' (Hausa conversion)
- *Kano* → Ḥ (established spelling)

8.3 Numbers

Options for representing numbers:

1. **Arabic-Indic Numerals:** • ٠١٢٣٤٥٦٧٨٩
2. **Eastern Arabic-Indic:** Used in some regions
3. **Western Numerals:** 0123456789 (often retained)
4. **Spelled Out:** Written as words

Recommendation: Use Western numerals for computational clarity unless cultural context requires Arabic-Indic forms.

8.4 Punctuation

Arabic script punctuation conventions:

Table 13: Punctuation in Ajami		
Function	Latin	Ajami
Comma	,	؁
Question mark	?	؟
Semicolon	;	؛
Period/Full stop	.	؂ or ؃
Quotation marks	"..."	«CCC»

9 Validation and Quality Assurance

9.1 Round-Trip Conversion

Test conversion fidelity through back-conversion:

1. Convert Latin → Ajami
2. Attempt reverse conversion Ajami → Latin
3. Compare with original
4. Calculate character-level similarity

Success Criteria:

- Character similarity > 70% for valid conversion
- Phonological preservation: all phonemes recoverable
- Lexical preservation: word boundaries maintained

9.2 Common Conversion Errors

Type 1: Digraph Mishandling

- *Error:* Converting "ts" as separate "t" + "s"
- *Correct:* *tsari* → 'تساري' (not 'ت اري')

Type 2: Long Vowel Omission

- *Error:* Treating "aa" as two separate "a"s
- *Correct:* *gaa* → 'گaa' (not 'گaa')

Type 3: Implosive/Plosive Confusion

- *Error:* Using standard "b" for implosive "
- *Correct:* *era* → 'ءرا' (not 'برا')

9.3 Quality Metrics

Evaluate conversion systems using:

1. **Character-Level Accuracy:** Percentage of correctly mapped characters
2. **Word-Level Accuracy:** Percentage of fully correct word conversions
3. **Phonological Preservation:** Retention of phonemic distinctions
4. **Human Readability:** Native reader comprehension (>90% target)

10 Implementation Guidelines

10.1 Algorithmic Implementation

Pseudocode for Complete Conversion:

```
FUNCTION  hausa_to_ajami(text):
    // Stage 1: Normalization
    text = lowercase(text)
    text = remove_punctuation_preserve_structure(text)

    // Stage 2: Phonological Segmentation
    syllables = segment_into_syllables(text)

    // Stage 3: Character Mapping (Longest Match First)
    ajami_text = ""
    position = 0
    WHILE position < length(text):
        // Try trigraphs (3 chars)
        IF text[position:position+3] IN trigraph_map:
            ajami_text += trigraph_map[text[position:position+3]]
            position += 3
        // Try digraphs (2 chars)
        ELSE IF text[position:position+2] IN digraph_map:
            ajami_text += digraph_map[text[position:position+2]]
            position += 2
        // Try single characters
        ELSE IF text[position] IN character_map:
            ajami_text += character_map[text[position]]
            position += 1
        // Handle unknown characters
        ELSE:
            ajami_text += text[position]      // Preserve unknown
            position += 1

    // Stage 4: Diacritization
    ajami_text = apply_sukun_rules(ajami_text)
    ajami_text = apply_shadda_rules(ajami_text)
    ajami_text = apply_vowel_diacritics(ajami_text)

    // Stage 5: Post-processing
```

```

ajami_text = apply_ligature_rules(ajami_text)
ajami_text = set_rtl_directionality(ajami_text)

RETURN ajami_text

```

10.2 Data Structures

Mapping Tables (Python Dict Example):

```

# Trigraphs (check first)
trigraph_map = {} # None for Hausa

# Digraphs (check second)
digraph_map = {
    'ts': '\u062A\u0652\u0633\u0652', #
    'sh': '\u0634\u0652', #
    'ng': '\u0646\u0652\u06AF\u0652', #
    'aa': '\u0627\u064E', #
    'ee': '\u0627\u0650', #
    'ii': '\u0627\u0650\u064A', #
    'oo': '\u0627\u064F', #
    'uu': '\u0627\u064F\u0648', #
    'y': '\u08A9', #
}

# Single characters (check last)
character_map = {
    ' ': '\u0752', #
    ' ': '\u068E', #
    ' ': '\u08BC', #
    'b': '\u0628', #
    'c': '\u0686', #
    'd': '\u062F', #
    # ... (complete mapping from tables above)
}

```

10.3 Unicode Handling

Critical Unicode Considerations:

1. **Normalization:** Use NFD (decomposed) or NFC (composed) consistently
2. **Combining Characters:** Diacritics are combining characters (U+0300-U+036F range)
3. **Bidirectional Text:** Set Unicode direction markers (U+200F for RTL)
4. **Zero-Width Characters:** May be needed for complex ligatures

Python Example:

```
import unicodedata

def normalize_arabic(text):
    # Normalize to composed form (NFC)
    text = unicodedata.normalize('NFC', text)

    # Add RTL mark if needed
    if has_arabic_script(text):
        text = '\u200F' + text    # Right-to-left mark

    return text
```

11 Testing and Validation

11.1 Test Corpus

Comprehensive testing should include:

1. **Phonological Coverage:** All 32 consonants + 10 vowels
2. **Syllable Types:** V, CV, VC, CVC patterns
3. **Morphological Complexity:** Affixes, clitics, compounds
4. **Sentence Structures:** Declarative, interrogative, imperative
5. **Mixed Scripts:** Code-mixing with Arabic, English

11.2 Validation Checklist

Table 14: Conversion Validation Checklist

Validation Criterion	Status
All Hausa-specific consonants correctly mapped (, ,)	☐
Long vowels distinguished from short vowels	☐
Digraphs (ts, sh, ng) handled as single units	☐
Sukun applied to consonant clusters	☐
Shadda applied to geminated consonants	☐
Short vowel diacritics correctly placed	☐
Word boundaries preserved	☐
Sentence punctuation converted	☐
Arabic loanwords identified (if applicable)	☐
Round-trip conversion achieves >70% similarity	☐
Native speaker readability validated	☐

12 Conclusion and Future Work

12.1 Summary

This document has provided comprehensive rules for Hausa-to-Ajami script conversion, including:

- Phonologically-grounded character mappings
- Detailed handling of Hausa-specific phonemes
- Diacritization rules for disambiguation
- Implementation algorithms and data structures
- Validation procedures and quality metrics

12.2 Limitations

Current conversion rules have limitations:

1. **Tone Marking:** Hausa tones not fully represented in Ajami
2. **Dialectal Variation:** Rules based on Kano standard dialect

3. **Code-Mixing:** Automatic detection of loanwords imperfect
4. **Informal Orthography:** Social media spellings may not conform

12.3 Future Enhancements

Recommended areas for extension:

1. **Machine Learning:** Neural models for context-sensitive conversion
2. **Dialect Adaptation:** Conversion rules for other Hausa varieties
3. **Tone Representation:** Supplementary tone marking system
4. **Interactive Tools:** Web-based converter with user feedback
5. **Corpus Development:** Parallel Latin-Ajami corpus for validation

Acknowledgments

This conversion framework builds on decades of Hausa linguistic scholarship, particularly the work of Paul Newman, Roxana Ma Newman, and the Ajami documentation efforts led by Fallou Ngom and Meikal Mumin.

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A Complete Character Mapping Reference

A.1 Quick Reference Table

Table 15: Complete Hausa-to-Ajami Character Mapping

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Type
<i>Hausa-Specific Consonants</i>				
	[]	پ	U+0752	Implosive
	[]	ڙ	U+068E	Implosive
	[k]	و	U+08BC	Ejective
'y	[j]	ي	U+08A9	Glottalized
<i>Digraphs</i>				
ts	[ts]	ٲ	U+062A U+0652 U+0633 U+0652	Affricate
sh	[]	ش	U+0634 U+0652	Fricative
ng	[ŋ]	°	U+0646 U+0652 U+06AF U+0652	Nasal
<i>Long Vowels</i>				
aa	[a]	'1	U+0627 U+064E	Long
ee	[e]	1	U+0627 U+0650	Long
ii	[i]	ي1	U+0627 U+0650 U+064A	Long
oo	[o]	1°	U+0627 U+064F	Long
uu	[u]	p1°	U+0627 U+064F U+0648	Long
<i>Standard Consonants</i>				
b	[b]	ب	U+0628	Plosive
c	[t]	چ	U+0686	Affricate
d	[d]	س	U+062F	Plosive
f	[f]	ف	U+0641	Fricative
g	[]	ك	U+06AF	Plosive
h	[h]	ه	U+0647	Fricative

Latin	IPA	Ajami	Unicode	Type
j	[d]	ج	U+062C	Affricate
k	[k]	ك	U+0643	Plosive
l	[l]	ل	U+0644	Liquid
m	[m]	م	U+0645	Nasal
n	[n]	ن	U+0646	Nasal
r	[r]	ر	U+0631	Liquid
s	[s]	س	U+0633	Fricative
t	[t]	ت	U+062A	Plosive
w	[w]	پ	U+0648	Glide
y	[j]	ي	U+064A	Glide
z	[z]	ز	U+0632	Fricative
'	[]	ع	U+0639	Glottal
<i>Short Vowels (Diacritics)</i>				
a	[a]	'	U+064E	Fatha
e	[e]	◌َ	U+0650	Kasra
i	[i]	◌ِ	U+0650	Kasra
o	[o]	◌ُ	U+064F	Damma
u	[u]	◌ُو	U+064F	Damma

B Sample Texts

B.1 Proverb Examples

Proverb 1:

Latin: Kowane mai sanyi, da rani ya zo, zai ji zafi.

Ajami: كَوَانِي مَائِي سَانِي، دَارَانِي يَزُو، زَائِي جِي زَافِي

Translation: "Whoever is cold, when summer comes, will feel heat."

Meaning: Everyone's situation changes; fortunes reverse.

Proverb 2:

Latin: Hannu daya ba ya aukan tudun kasua.

Ajami: هَانُّ دَايَا بَا يَا أَوَّكَا تُوْدُونُ كَاسُوَا

Translation: "One hand cannot lift the marketplace roof."

Meaning: Cooperation is necessary for big tasks.

B.2 Short Narrative

Latin: Wata rana, an sara i ya tafi daji. Ya ga dabba mai girma. Ya yi tsoro, ya gudu zuwa gida.

Ajami: پٽ رنڊڻ اهو ئي آهي ته سچو ئي ڪرڻ بابت جي ڏاڍي چڱائي ۽ محنت سان

پٺڻ

Translation: "One day, the prince went to the forest. He saw a big animal. He became afraid and ran home."